CSIS KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Thursday, October 29, 2026 No. 218 11 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korea fired approximately 10 short-range ballistic missiles from Wonsan toward the East Sea, days after Seoul proposed military dialogue.
2. South Korea's National Intelligence Service told lawmakers Kim Jong Un may have used his Dandong visit to convey Pyongyang's position on US talks.
3. Prosecutors sought the death penalty for former President Yoon Suk Yeol over the December 3 martial law declaration.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,937.66	1,337.89	$110.19	39%	Oct 25	2.50%
−1.2%	+0.8%	−4.5%	+2 pts Oct 13-15	4 days ago	Oct 2026

01 TOP STORIES

NK News, DPRK

North Korea fires ~10 short-range ballistic missiles from Wonsan, days after Seoul dialogue offer

North Korea launched a salvo of approximately 10 short-range ballistic missiles (SRBMs) from the Wonsan area toward the East Sea at around 12:30 p.m. Korea Standard Time on October 29, the ROK Joint Chiefs of Staff announced.

The missiles flew approximately 250 km, with the US and South Korea conducting joint precision analysis. The launches came days after Defense Minister **Kang Shin-chul** publicly called on Pyongyang to return to dialogue at the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus) in the Philippines.

Korea Times / Yonhap, NK-Russia-China

NIS: Kim Jong Un may have used Dandong visit to convey Pyongyang's position on US talks

South Korea's National Intelligence Service told lawmakers in a closed-door intelligence committee audit that **Kim Jong Un** may have conveyed Pyongyang's stance on potential talks with the United States during his October 24 visit to Dandong, China.

The NIS noted Kim was accompanied by senior diplomats including Foreign Minister Choe Son-hui rather than military officials, suggesting a purpose beyond commemorating China's Korean War anniversary participation. The NIS added that China could relay Kim's position to Washington but does not appear to have the will to act as a broker.

Washington Post / AP, ROK Politics

Prosecutors seek death penalty for former President Yoon Suk Yeol over December martial law

South Korean prosecutors have requested the death penalty for former President **Yoon Suk Yeol** in connection with his December 3, 2025 declaration of martial law. The prosecution's demand represents the most severe penalty sought in the case against Yoon, who was impeached and removed from office following the failed declaration. The trial remains ongoing in Seoul.

02 | OVERNIGHT

NK News, NK-Russia-China

Report links North Korean overseas workers to Russian military-industrial supply chain

Network disguises employment as education to evade sanctions.

FT, NK-Russia-China

North Korean labor advertised online to Russian factories, FT investigation finds

Russian firms and individuals facilitate pipeline deepening economic NK-Russia ties.

The Hill, DPRK

Treasury sanctions 8 North Koreans and 2 Russians for IT worker fraud targeting US businesses

OFAC designated 10 individuals and one entity for generating revenue for DPRK weapons programs.

NK News, US-Korea

US-ROK defense chiefs defer annual Security Consultative Meeting to early 2027

Delay sets back Seoul's wartime operational control transfer timeline.

Korea JoongAng Daily, ROK Economy

KHNP vows no delay on Czech nuclear project after construction consortium talks collapse

Korea Hydro and Nuclear Power seeking new builders for the 25 trillion won Dukovany project.

Reuters, Technology

South Korean court rejects Tesla owners' lawsuit seeking Full Self-Driving refunds

Seoul court ruled against plaintiffs claiming delayed FSD feature delivery.

Nikkei, Japan-Korea

Mirae Asset to acquire proprietary trading unit of Japan's Okasan Securities

Deal extends Korean financial firm's Japan footprint.

Dong-A Ilbo, Technology

Millions of cyber scans hit South Korea's financial sector from North Korean IP addresses

Up to 4.4 million hacking attempts in a single day traced to DPRK-linked addresses.

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

10

Short-range ballistic missiles fired by DPRK from Wonsan, Oct 29

North Korea launched the salvo hours after Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul, at the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus in the Philippines, called on Pyongyang to return to dialogue.

NK News / ROK Joint Chiefs of Staff, Oct 29

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 4 days ago

No KCNA watch flag. 4 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

38 North

North Korea Continues Installing New Fencing

38 North satellite imagery analysis shows North Korea continuing to install new fencing along its border, extending the fortification trend documented throughout 2026.

Daily NK

North Korean journalists told to trade reporting duties for ideology drills marking journalists' union 80th anniversary

In Ryanggang province, North Korean journalists at the provincial party newspaper are required to set year-end loyalty pledges and attend mandatory ideological sessions that consume more time than normal reporting duties.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Choe Son-hui, DPRK Foreign Minister

Accompanied Kim Jong Un on his October 24 Dandong visit, a delegation composition the NIS cited as evidence the trip had a diplomatic rather than purely ceremonial purpose.

> **Bottom line:** North Korea launched approximately 10 short-range ballistic missiles from Wonsan on October 29, days after the ROK defense minister called for dialogue; state media covered the Pyongyang trade fair and harvest mobilization but had not reported on the launches as of this digest.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Thursday, October 29, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

FM Cho Hyun

FM Cho Hyun departs for the US for G20 sherpa meeting and bilateral talks with Rubio

Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun** left for the United States to participate in a G20-related meeting and hold bilateral talks with US Secretary of State **Marco Rubio**. Separately, ROK G20 Sherpa Kim Hee-sang met with Indonesia's G20 Sherpa Edi Prio Pambudi on October 29 to discuss cooperation ahead of the December 14-15 Miami G20 summit and preparations for Korea's 2028 G20 presidency.

The Korea Times
Reported **Foreign Ministry**

NATIONAL INTELLIGENCE SERVICE

NIS Director

NIS disciplines staff who followed unlawful December 3 martial law orders

The NIS announced that a special audit found approximately 10 staff members followed unlawful orders from former Director Jo Tae-yong and other political appointees on the day of the December 3 martial law declaration; those staff will face disciplinary action. The NIS reported this finding to the National Assembly intelligence committee audit.

Yonhap

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Closed-door NIS audit yields Kim China visit assessment and martial law discipline findings

National Assembly Intelligence Committee

Ruling Democratic Party Rep. Yoon Kun-young and People Power Party Rep. Yoo Yeong-ha both readout the NIS closed-door audit: Kim Jong Un may have conveyed US-talks intentions via his Dandong trip, North Korean loudspeaker reports were false, and about 10 NIS staff who obeyed martial law orders will be disciplined.

Presidential secretariat audit disrupted over Kim Tae-gyu's participation

National Assembly Operations Committee

Ruling and opposition parties clashed at the reopened Blue House secretariat national audit over the participation of Kim Tae-gyu, with the Democratic Party demanding Kim apologize for denying that Yoon Suk Yeol and Chun Doo-hwan staged a coup; the session broke down before a non-participation agreement was reached.

06 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no single baseline reciprocal tariff rate. Section 301 investigations launched in March 2026 against 16 trading partners including South Korea are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding, $200B strategic sectors (capped $20B/yr), $100B US energy purchases; no official Strategic Investment Corporation drawdown figure reported to date.

07 | CAPITOL HILL

VOA, House, Legislation

US House introduces bill to block AI technology theft, names North Korea as country of concern

The House introduced legislation to prevent AI technology theft, explicitly listing North Korea among countries of concern; the bill would restrict AI-related technology transfers that could benefit designated adversaries.

Breitbart News, Statement

Report: South Korea has spent $363 million lobbying US lawmakers

A report cited by Breitbart News states South Korea has spent $363 million lobbying US lawmakers, a figure that has attracted congressional attention amid broader scrutiny of foreign government lobbying disclosures.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Financial Times, Russia-Korea

South Korean 'tilt' toward Russia alarms European allies, FT

The Financial Times reports that South Korea's diplomatic positioning toward Russia has alarmed European partners, amid Seoul's parallel reduction in diplomatic personnel in Ukraine over the North Korean prisoner-of-war dispute.

Nikkei, Russia-Korea

Russia imports North Korean workers disguised as students, report shows

A new investigation documents Russian firms and individuals disguising North Korean labor employment as education to circumvent international sanctions, linking those workers to companies supporting Russia's military-industrial complex.

Yonhap, China-Korea

China breaks nine-month silence on North Korea missile launches, calls for peace efforts

China's foreign ministry broke a nine-month silence on North Korea's ballistic missile launches, expressing hope that all parties concerned will make efforts toward peace, stopping short of condemning Pyongyang.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Reuters, Middle East, Diplomacy

South Korea says it is considering deployment options to the Strait of Hormuz, including aircraft

Seoul confirmed it is reviewing options for a military deployment to the Strait of Hormuz, including the possibility of aircraft, as part of broader discussions about contribution to maritime security in the region.

Ukrainian news, Ukraine, Diplomacy

South Korea has not ruled out severing diplomatic ties with Ukraine if POW escalation continues

Seoul has not excluded the possibility of cutting diplomatic relations with Ukraine if the dispute over North Korean prisoner-of-war soldiers held by Kyiv continues to escalate; South Korea previously withdrew 8 diplomatic personnel from Ukraine.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Dong-A Ilbo

SK Innovation posts record Q3 operating profit of 3.7 trillion won, up 533% year-on-year

3.7 trillion won in Q3 operating profit was driven by improved petroleum product export margins and lubricant business strength; revenue rose 39.7% year-on-year to 28.8 trillion won.

SK Innovation SK Energy

Reuters

Bank of Korea board member says won is moving faster than expected

A Bank of Korea board member told Reuters the won is moving faster than anticipated, a signal of concern about exchange rate volatility at a time when the KOSPI fell 1.24% on October 29.

Bank of Korea

Washington Post

South Korea's communications regulator fines Google and Apple over app payment practices

South Korea's media commission fined Google and Apple for unfair app market practices related to payment systems, extending Seoul's tech platform enforcement actions against US firms.

Google Apple

Bloomberg

Bloomberg Fed's Warsh explains why he watches Korea's economy closely

Federal Reserve Governor **Kevin Warsh** cited Korea's economy as a key leading indicator he monitors, pointing to its semiconductor export performance as a barometer for global technology demand.

SBS

Bithumb hack exposes personal data of 6,444 customers including passport numbers

Cryptocurrency exchange Bithumb disclosed that a cyberattack on its internal systems leaked personal information of 6,444 customers, with 5,600 of those cases including identification document copies.

Bithumb

11 | UPCOMING

NOV 1

BOK publishes 2027 Monetary Policy Committee schedule

The Bank of Korea confirmed the 2027 Monetary Policy Committee meeting schedule, with the first rate decision set for January 14, 2027.

NOV 15

Korea Grand Festival consumer discount event closes

The 2026 Korea Grand Festival, a national-scale consumption promotion integrating 40,000 businesses, runs October 29 through November 15.

DEC 14

G20 Leaders' Summit, Miami

ROK FM Cho Hyun travels to the US and ROK G20 Sherpa met with Indonesia's sherpa on Oct 29 to coordinate positions ahead of the December 14-15 Miami G20 summit.

12 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

ROK Ministry of National Defense (@ROK_MND), Primary, October 29

“Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul attended the 13th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus) in the Philippines on October 29, his first multilateral security forum since taking office, where he assessed the regional security situation and discussed cooperation for peace and stability.”

Kang also held bilateral defense talks with counterparts from Malaysia, India, the Philippines, and Australia on October 28 on the sidelines of the same forum. **View on X**

Gen. Xavier Brunson (@CDRUNCCFCUSFK), October 29

“We call them the 'Chosin Few.' Their courage in 1950 helped forge the Alliance we stand on today. At the War Memorial of Korea, I laid a wreath in their honor. Their sacrifice endures. Our commitment must, too.”

Gen. Brunson's wreath-laying at the War Memorial of Korea on October 29 coincides with the fourth anniversary of the Itaewon disaster and the day of North Korea's 10-missile salvo. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Lee Jae-myung

“There was no state on that day. In the place where the state should have reached out first, the bereaved families had to demand truth and accountability from the state.”

President Lee attended the fourth anniversary of the October 29, 2022 Itaewon crowd crush that killed 160 people; People Power Party leader Jang Dong-hyuk did not attend, per Korean reporting. **Source**

COMMENTARY

Bridge to Beijing? Kim Jong-un Crosses the Yalu. CSIS analysis of Kim Jong Un's October 24 Dandong visit examines why the trip differs from prior patterns, specifically the presence of Foreign Minister Choe Son-hui and other diplomats rather than military officials, and Kim's use of the newly opened New Yalu River Bridge. The piece explores whether Beijing could serve as a conduit for Pyongyang's position on potential US talks. (CSIS)

OPCON: Washington wants flexibility, Seoul wants control. Lowy Institute analysis examines the structural gap in the wartime operational control (OPCON) transfer debate: Seoul seeks command authority as a sovereignty marker, while Washington needs to retain flexibility over how US forces are used in broader contingencies beyond Korea. The piece contextualizes the October 29 announcement deferring the Security Consultative Meeting on OPCON to early 2027. (lowyinstitute.org)

How War Memorialization Legitimizes the Russia-DPRK Alliance and Strengthens Kim Jong Un's Legitimacy. 38 North analyst Nika Pasko examines how war commemoration events, including the first road bridge linking Russia and North Korea across the Tumen River opened in September 2026 and the CPV anniversary activities surrounding Kim's Dandong visit, serve as institutional legitimation tools for the Russia-DPRK alliance. The analysis traces how memorialization of shared 'blood alliances' strengthens Kim's domestic authority while providing rhetorical cover for ongoing military cooperation. (Nika Pasko, NK)

13 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

+2 pts vs Oct 6-8
Gallup Korea
October 13-15, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 6 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
36%	27%	29%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 2 weeks old (October 13-15, 2026).

14 | THE WIRE

DPRK

NK News

NIS: Reports of North Korea testing loudspeakers aimed at South are false

South Korea's NIS told the National Assembly intelligence committee that a border-area resident made an erroneous report; Paju City officials said they could not determine what happened.

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NK News

Chinese travel agency claims invitation to organize youth tours to North Korea's Wonsan Kalma resort

A Chinese agency called Offline posted on social media it had been invited to run tours from late October, though a tourism insider expressed skepticism the trips will take place.

38 North

38 North quick take: Kim's Dandong trip was unusual and differs from past pre-summit China visits

38 North analysis by Rachel Minyoung Lee notes Kim's October 24 same-day trip via the New Yalu River Bridge was framed around the Chinese People's Volunteer Army anniversary, diverging from the pattern of extended visits preceding diplomatic breakthroughs.

US-KOREA

Yonhap

President Lee vows to strengthen US-ROK alliance at Korean War battle ceremony

President **Lee Jae-myung** pledged to reinforce the alliance at a ceremony marking a Korean War battle, hours after North Korea's missile salvo.

TRILATERAL

Anadolu Ajansı

US Defense Secretary Hegseth meets ROK, Japan, India, Australia defense chiefs at ADMM-Plus in Philippines

US Defense Secretary **Pete Hegseth** held bilateral defense talks with his South Korean counterpart **Kang Shin-chul** on the sidelines of the 13th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus, emphasizing the alliance is built on peace through strength.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

MONITORING

Yellow Sea NLL

As of September 26, 2025: 140m DPRK merchant vessel Toksong crossed the Northern Limit Line near Baengnyeong Island, advanced 5km south. ROK Navy fired approximately 60 warning shots; vessel retreated after 1 hour. ROK Marine Corps Commandant Gen. Ju Il-suk stated October 20 2026 that North Korea has made 'various changes' to forces facing South Korea's border islands, with Seoul stepping up surveillance along the maritime border. 38 North satellite imagery published October 29 shows North Korea continuing to install new fencing along its border.

imagery as of 2026-10-29

10 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 218

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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